

EFFECTIVE **DISAGREEMENT**

BY MATTHEW JOHNSON

HOW TO:

**LEAD THROUGH
CONFLICT
WITHOUT LOSING
TRUST, TALENT,
OR PURPOSE**

Dedication

To Jennifer: my wife and best friend for the past 25 years. She sees something in me that I have difficulty seeing in myself. I appreciate your love and support and for being there for me despite the times when I don't show up as my best self. Even when my ability to effectively disagree is rocky at best, I know you have my back. And I have yours.

To Carlos Garcia: Thank you for your leadership, your mentorship, but more importantly, your friendship. This book would not be possible without your encouragement and advice.

PROLOGUE

We keep saying we want better leadership. But what we really want is less disagreement that makes us uncomfortable. I have watched good leaders leave their organizations not because they were wrong, but because disagreement became punishment.

They did not leave in protest. They did not slam doors. They left quietly, exhausted by rooms where questions were treated as threats and honesty was repaid with suspicion. They left because every disagreement became a character indictment. Every boundary became a political liability. Every attempt to clarify reality became evidence that they were “the problem.” Over time, they learned what everyone eventually learns in a broken system: it is safer to be silent than to be right.

This is not a book about bad people. It is a book about bad incentives. About institutions that accidentally trained their leaders to avoid truth, reward performance over courage, and mistake volume for accountability. Somewhere along the way, we stopped teaching people how to disagree well. We stopped modeling what principled dissent looks like. We stopped protecting the space where hard conversations can happen without becoming public executions. And then we acted surprised when disagreement turned toxic.

What we call a “leadership crisis” is often a disagreement crisis in disguise. We say people are thin-skinned. We say the culture has become too divided. We say social media ruined everything. But underneath all of that is a simpler, more uncomfortable truth: we no longer know how to hold tension without turning it into warfare. We no longer know how to challenge ideas without humiliating people. We no longer

know how to tell the truth without burning the bridge behind us.

So people adapt. They soften what they really think. They delay what they should say. They translate their judgment into something safer and smaller. Not because they are dishonest, but because they are trying to survive. And when enough people do this long enough, institutions do not collapse. They hollow out. They keep functioning, but they stop learning. They keep meeting, but they stop improving. They keep talking, but they stop telling the truth.

This book is for people who still care too much to go quiet.

It is for leaders who feel the daily tension between honesty and employability. Between stewardship and self-protection. Between doing what is right and doing what will keep the room calm. It is for public servants, executives, managers, board members, and professionals who have learned to read the room so well that they have forgotten how to speak into it.

Effective disagreement is not about winning arguments. It is not about being provocative. And it is not about performing courage in front of an audience. It is about learning how to stay anchored to the truth, committed to the relationship, and loyal to the mission at the same time. It is about choosing language, timing, and restraint that make hard conversations possible instead of explosive. It is about protecting institutions from decay by restoring disagreement as a discipline, not a defect.

Disagreement is not going away. The stakes are only getting higher. The pressure is only getting louder. And the cost of silence is only getting steeper.

The question is not whether you will face disagreement as a leader. You already do.

The question is whether you will learn how to lead through it without losing your integrity, your people, or the institution you are trying to serve.

That is what this book is about.

WHO IS THIS BOOK FOR?

CHAPTER 1: WHY DISAGREEMENT IS BROKEN - AND WHAT IT'S COSTING US.

I would like to begin with story about a young professional at a public meeting. He was prepared for the large audience who had come to protest the decisions being made. He was convinced the facts were on his side, but about to learn that being right is not the same as being effective. Most of the seats were filled and a few people gathered along the sides of the room. The air was thick and his palms were sweaty.

He was a young urban planner and the Town had recently completed a nearly year-long update to its Comprehensive Plan, which is a document that outlines how the Town would like to grow over the next few years. The community was just exiting the painful recession of 2008 and development interest in the area had perked up slightly. Partially because of the pain of the recent recession and partly because of a desire to see more businesses to help support the small community, the new plan called for extending the business district slightly along the western portion of Main Street.

A request had come in for a new restaurant with a drive-thru. A national chain. And the citizens didn't want any part of it. "Our whole town will smell like chicken.," reported one citizen. "The kids will be running across the street for food from the elementary school!," cried another. The sentiment of the crowd was clear - say "NO" to the request. And then it happened.

The young man stepped up to the microphone and slowly began to read a speech that he had written. He chastised them for not attending the planning sessions that had yielded the new Comprehensive Plan which clearly recommended this action. He chided them for not understanding urban planning principles. He nearly called their way of thinking “backwards”, but the idea was still implied. And in that one evening, he made one of the biggest mistakes of his professional career. All because he didn’t know the best way to communicate.

That young professional was me. And it cost me dearly. I was fortunate enough to keep my job. That was thanks to a progressive manager that I respected who only asked me one question afterwards. “What did we learn from that?”, she asked. Board members were gracious to me and asked me for advice on how to repair what I had done. And, two months later, I issued a public apology and the Board denied the request and subsequently made changes to the Comprehensive Plan to offer some solace to the community that this wouldn’t be an issue again. Fast forward to 2026 and this same property is again at the center of a very contentious request once again. But more on that later.

That painful lesson in 2010 triggered something in me and I have spent the last 15+ years seeking out better ways to engage with the community, with my staff, with our Board members, and with everyday people that I meet. “There must be a way that we can disagree respectfully”, I thought. And I have been on a mission to discover ways that we can be effective in our disagreements.

Disagreements did not become toxic because people got worse. It became toxic because we have stopped teaching how to disagree **well**. People haven’t suddenly become unreasonable. Rather, our environments have stopped rewarding restraint and institutions have stopped modeling disagreement as a skillset.

In healthy organizations, disagreements used to be structured. There were clear lanes for challenge, roles were understood, and timing mattered. Often, disagreements were tested internally before being made public. Public forums were for decision-making, not dominance. Leaders knew how to question without humiliating and staff knew how to push back without defying. Too often now, silence has become the default strategy because it is “safe”.

Disagreements served a shared outcome because winning the argument was secondary to improving the work. After all, disagreement was a tool of leadership, not a test of loyalty.

Nowadays, things seem to be *different*. In public, professional, and civic life, disagreement has shifted into something else entirely. We are observing disagreements become *performative*. In a sense, the audience has come to matter more than the outcome. Perhaps this is a result of the implementation of social media which rewards engagement (click, likes, shares, etc.). No longer are we seeking to actually solve an issue or advance the work, we are seeking to make a spectacle for performance sake. We see leaders, staff members, and citizens making statements which are crafted for **reaction** instead of **resolution**.

Performance is saying things that will get the speaker noticed. It mistakes visibility for bravery. I see the comments on social media where the audience gives virtual back-slaps and attaboys to the post’s author for statements that are just plainly false. Social media has become a source of great disagreement because it is the safest place to do so. You can literally create your own bubble or echo-chamber where your audience rewards your “performances”. From a distance, performance looks like courage. But, up close, it is often just fear wearing a microphone.

When the person disagreeing actually has the courage to state such in public, I have noticed that it often being pushed

to happen in front of spectators. The better the opportunity for someone to casually video the interaction, clip it, take items out of context, and push a particular narrative. Any attempt to clarify questions, concerns, or to simply have a conversation in a more private setting is seen as suspicious and “non-transparent”. Additionally, I have noticed that disagreement quickly escalates into a referendum on *values* rather than ideas. To disagree is to *become* the problem. Sides are chosen and, once entrenched, the other side must be annihilated at all costs.

Ever had a someone send pages of emails or post online repeating the same misinformed narrative for years despite many attempts to offer up a simple discussion to clarify the issues? When people lack the skill to disagree well, they reach for the only lever they have left: volume. They will inundate others with sheer volumes of “data” rather than substitute that with clarity. Their outrage has taken the place of authority and repetition substitutes for evidence.

All of these tactics point to a population that is unskilled in how to effectively disagree. To disagree requires courage. It means saying the hard thing early. Correcting misinformation quietly. Standing firm without spectacle. And, accepting discomfort without applause. Skilled disagreements look like knowing when to speak; using precise language; having good timing; showing restraint; and knowing when **not** to speak. Volume looks like: repetition, escalation, using a louder tone instead of clearer thinking; and pushing “certainty” without first understanding.

Why does this all matter? When we can’t disagree safely and effectively, the organization suffers. Relationships suffer. Decisions get worse and staff stop raising concerns. Ultimately, the loudest voices begin to shape your reality. When disagreement becomes unsafe, the damage does not show up as chaos, it shows up as *compliance*. While most leaders are on the lookout for explosions, the real danger is

quiet. Silence shows up as alignment until the decision fails. And I have been keenly aware of this because I've been on the silent side. I watched as one of my managers made blunder after blunder - publicly and privately. I chose the path of silence because they had created a culture where disagreement meant punishment, mockery, or public shaming. I stopped offering advice, stopped mitigating risks to the organization, and simply waited for instructions instead of contributing to the greater work that needed to be done. It was wrong, and I knew it. But at that time, I couldn't afford to lose my job.

When I became a Manager, I knew that I couldn't do it alone. I needed a trusted advisor who would be willing to disagree with me. And my job was to trust her and to listen to her. I found that partner because I was willing to listen. I had learned that skillset by watching others fail. She has not disappointed. My Assistant Manager is thoughtful, trustworthy, witty, and brutally honest, as well as one of the greatest human beings I have ever worked with.

When I was under the thumb of the difficult manager, I could only focus on one thing - how am I going to get out of here? I had figured out that the organization was a place where good judgement was not valued and I wanted out. Hindsight is always 20/20 and I should have left **way** before I did. But I wasn't a quitter and I had convinced myself that I needed the job. One of the more significant costs of not being able to disagree or even have open communication is the loss of talent. High-capacity people often choose to leave before they break. I'm not talking about dramatic exits, I'm talking about *erosion*. In that difficult job (where I should have left earlier), the organization lost four department-head level employees in three months. It should have been a signal, but it wasn't. You don't lose your loudest employees first. You lose your more thoughtful ones. And it takes a toll on your bottom line. The cost of hiring and retraining key leadership employees can be upwards of 200%+ of their annual salary.

When the culture of the organization deters disagreement, risk becomes a killer. Leaders do not want to be criticized and default to “safe” positions which cannot be challenged. Innovation slows to a trickle and decisions get smaller, safer, and slower, killing the organization slowly and methodically. Risk doesn’t actually disappear, it just goes unexamined.

On January 28, 1986, I was 9 years old and I was at home because the east coast of the United States was experiencing some winter weather. Our schools had been cancelled, but I was watching the Challenger space shuttle launch from Florida on television. When the tragedy occurred, I was in complete shock. I knew immediately that kind of accident wasn’t survivable. At the time, we didn’t know exactly what had happened and the truth wouldn’t be told for quite some time.

The Challenger disaster stands as one of the clearest case studies in what happens when disagreement exists but is not allowed to do its job. The failure wasn’t a mystery to NASA’s contracted engineers, who had warned NASA the evening before the launch that the rubber O-rings sealing the solid rocket boosters were vulnerable to cold temperatures. Launch morning temperatures were well below anything the engineers had previously tested. Warnings were issued, data was cited, and charts were shown. Yet, under scheduling pressure and political expectations, the conversation shifted. Engineers were asked to “prove” it was unsafe. In a reversal of burden, disagreement was technically present but it was neutralized.

This is where effective disagreement draws a hard moral line. It is not merely about allowing dissent to be heard, rather it is about allowing conversations where dissent cannot be softened, sidelined, or punished. In an organization where disagreements exist to improve the work, such a warning would have not been a ‘speed bump’ but it would have been

a 'stop' signal. The Challenger story teaches that unexamined risk does not fade - it compounds. And when leaders lack the language and structures to protect principled dissent, catastrophe does not arrive as a shock. It arrives right on schedule.

When judgement goes quiet, confidence takes over. And in the absence of skilled disagreement, authority often shifts to the loudest voices. Influence drifts toward whoever speaks with the most certainty, the most frequency, or the most volume. Not because they are *right*, but because they are present. Those speaking with the most certainty almost always begin to seem like they are the most competent. And, over time, the loudest voice in the room becomes the de facto decision-maker, even if they hold no authority at all.

This shift is often very subtle and almost never acknowledged. The voices inside leaders' heads tell them they are being "responsive" or "transparent", when in reality they are being shaped by the most insistent personalities. Have you ever been in a meeting with someone who reflects these traits? Did you notice that the meeting begins to orbit around them? Agendas start to bend toward those who are the loudest, produces the most volume of 'stuff' for people to consider, or escalates the fastest. The organization begins solving for noise rather than seeking truth and because silence looks like agreement, dissent quietly disappears from the room. What is left is not consensus, it's compliance.

Long-term damage to organizations is profound when the loudest voices begin to dominate. Once people learn that influence flows to volume instead of judgment, they stop trying to make thoughtful contributions and begin preparing performances. The real tragedy is that the people most capable of improving decisions are often the ones who go quiet first, because they refuse to compete in a marketplace of outrage. And the organization suffers.

Instead of leading, executives begin spending energy decoding emotions, managing fallout, and anticipating reactions instead of shaping outcomes. Leadership energy gets spent buffering dysfunction instead of directing progress. And the end result is burnout. Ask me how I know.

In my career as a executive leading an organization, I have experienced this first-hand. The shift from leading progressive initiatives to managing dysfunction escalated quickly. There is a quiet but profound shift that happens when your energy moves from building the future to buffering dysfunction. Instead of spending time strengthening teams, improving systems, and delivering better outcomes for the community, more and more energy is diverted into translation, damage control, and emotional containment. I began managing noise instead of momentum and trying to absorb volatility so the staff don't have to. The cost is not just personal, it is institutional. Every hour spent stabilizing dysfunction is an hour not spent improving services, solving real problems, or moving the community forward.

This is one of the hidden prices of unresolved disagreement and politicized misinformation. When leadership becomes relative instead of generative, progress slows without anyone formally voting for it to slow. Nothing collapses dramatically. Things simply stop moving in the right direction. The tragedy is that from the outside it can look like "strong oversight" or "healthy skepticism", when in reality it is a tax on capacity, morale, and long-term performance. The work still gets done. It just becomes heavier, slower, and with less joy than it should. And, it results in massive burnout and turnover in the organization, which is a net loss to the community.

When disagreement becomes unsafe, institutions do not immediately become corrupt. They become careful. People stop saying what they believe and start saying what it takes for them to survive. Ethics don't entirely disappear, but they become conditional. Truth becomes something that is timed,

softened, or strategically omitted. And, over time, individuals learn that moral clarity is not what is rewarded; predictability is. And, so the organization slowly trades its integrity for stability. Not because people are dishonest, but because honesty has become dangerous to their continued employment.

Rules still exist, meetings still happen, values are still printed on the wall. But the organization is hollow because the spirit behind those things has thinned. When saying the right thing becomes risky, people learn to say the 'safe' thing. When raising concerns leads to punishment, people reframe concerns as loyalty. The result is not a culture of actual 'wrongdoing', but one of quiet moral compromise.

Disagreement is how institutions test their own strength. In a well-built organization disagreement can reveal weaknesses early, while they are still fixable. In more fragile organizations, disagreements become threats, and so weaknesses are hidden instead of healed. Bad decisions go unchallenged and without challenge, small ethical shortcuts accumulate. Without anyone willing to interrupt the drift, organizations begin confusing harmony with health.

Sadly, this erosion is almost invisible from the inside. Most people believe they are still doing the right thing, but simply doing it within a shrinking moral perimeter. Over time, the organizations center of gravity shifts from truth to survival; from stewardship to self-protection; from leadership to risk management. And by the time anyone identifies what has been lost, the cost is no longer just reputational or operational - it's moral. The organization still functions, but it no longer stands for what it once did.

Disagreement is not the problem we need to solve. It is the capacity we need to rebuild. The decay you see in meetings, in morale, in decision quality, and in public trust is not a failure of values. It is a failure of skill, structure, and leadership

courage. We did not lose our way because people became worse. We lost our way because we stopped teaching, modeling, and protecting the craft of disagreement itself.

This book is not about winning arguments or managing personalities. It is about learning how to tell the truth without burning the bridge, how to hold the line without humiliating the other side, and how to lead through tension without sacrificing your integrity or your institution. In the chapters ahead, we will explore what effective disagreement actually looks like in practice, how leaders unintentionally make it unsafe, and how language, timing, structure, and restraint can turn conflict back into a tool for better decisions. And while the examples often come from my experiences in local government, the principles apply to all organizations and leaders in all industries.

If you are tired of choosing between being right and being effective, between being honest and being employable, or between keeping the peace and doing what is right, then this work is for you. The discipline of effective disagreement is learnable. Because what you say next, changes everything.

Leadership Rule: When disagreement becomes unsafe, silence becomes policy. And silence is never neutral.

What to Say Instead: “I want to make sure we are not mistaking volume for clarity. Let’s come back to the facts, the process, and the decision in front of us.”

CHAPTER 2: THE MYTH OF NEUTRAL LEADERSHIP

Every time a leader chooses neutrality in a conflict, they are not ‘staying out of it’, they are deciding who wins. There is no neutral position in a conflict. There is only the position that your silence creates. I call this the Neutrality Myth.

The Neutrality Myth says that leaders can stay out of conflict. But the truth is that leaders never *truly* stay out of conflict. They only choose which side their silence strengthens. I asked myself the following question, “Why do good leaders allow bad dynamics to persist?”. It’s because no one taught them what disagreement *requires*. Leaders believe they are being ‘fair’ by staying out of disagreements. They think that neutrality preserves trust and restraint equals professionalism. I used to think that, too.

Early in my tenure as a city manager, I believed deeply in being fair, calm, and ‘above the fray’. When disagreements flared between elected officials and the public or staff members, I told myself that my job was to remain neutral. To let people ‘vent’. To avoid escalating emotions. I thought that everything would settle if I chose not to take sides. I mistakenly thought that restraint was leadership. I learned my lesson in three minutes. This particular story happens to come from a public meeting, but I’ve watched the same dynamic play out in hospital boardrooms, retail back offices, and school administrative meetings: someone in authority stays silent while a staff member absorbs a public humiliation alone.

One night during a board meeting, a citizen began speaking during the public comment period. Like every other speaker, he had three minutes to speak. The rules were clear, the process was fair, the timer was visible and audible. When his time expired, a beeper sounded, just as it always does. The Clerk, who has done this hundreds of times before, did exactly what her job required. She let the timer run out. She did not interrupt him. She did not say a word. He stopped mid-sentence, turned toward her, and shouted, "TURN IT OFF". The room went still. He repeated that several times, struggling to finish his sentences that he was reading from his phone. The Sheriff's deputy in the room had begun to move towards the podium ever so slightly, awaiting a signal from the Mayor to escort this guy out of the room and end the disruption.

It was not just rude, it was dominating. It was an adult man publicly scolding a staff member for enforcing a neutral rule that she did not create and did not control. She did not respond, other than to say "no". She just sat there, doing her job. And, for a moment, so did I.

I felt the heat of it immediately. I knew he was wrong and that it crossed a line. And I knew the only reason he felt entitled to say it that way, in that room, was because he believed no one would stop him. The Board moved on and I was invited to give my report immediately following that outburst.

I felt my heart beating in my chest. I knew the attack was unfair. And I knew the staff member was being used as a proxy for his frustration. I wanted to say all kinds of things. But, I hesitated. I mustered up what courage I could and I said, "The speaker must have a bitter heart to attack a staff person who is just doing their job." I wanted to protect the process and save the Board members from additional frustration. So, I mostly stayed quiet. The meeting moved on, the agenda items closed, the cameras were turned off and

the meeting adjourned. But something else happened in the room that night, too.

Every staff member watching that night learned a lesson. Every citizen watching that night learned a lesson. And my Clerk learned one too. That lesson wasn't about time limits. It was about protection. After the meeting, she quietly told me that she understood. She did not want me to say more. She did not want to escalate anything. She was professional. And kind. Still, everyone had felt it. Because what actually hurt was not the man who yelled, it was the silence that followed him.

In that moment, I told myself that I was being 'neutral'. I told myself that I was preserving the tone of the meeting. But, what I was really doing was redistributing power. I had taught the room that a citizen could publicly humiliate a staff member for enforcing a rule and face no real consequences. I had taught my staff that dignity was negotiable. And I had taught that man that intimidation would work against us.

I did not stay out of the conflict. I had picked a side. Albeit, I had picked that side quietly. Later, it finally landed on me that I was not trying to be 'fair', I was trying to remain comfortable. And it was at my staff's expense, because inaction redistributes the power in the room. Authority does not disappear all at once - it migrates. It moves away from leaders who do not use it and toward individuals who are willing to impose themselves. If a leader does not interrupt harmful behavior, the room does not conclude that the leader is kind. Rather, the room concludes that the leader is optional. The most aggressive voice fills the vacuum left by silence, and when a leader refuses to shape the disagreement, the disagreement will shape the institution.

Neutrality feels like the most responsible posture that a leader can take. When conflict arises between two people, two factions, or two versions of reality, the instinct to "stay out

of it” often appears as maturity and wisdom. Leaders often justify this as restraint, fairness, or protecting the process by refusing to be drawn into the drama. And, on the surface, this logic is deeply appealing. After all, leaders are supposed to be poised, steady, stoic. They are taught to create space for everyone to be heard, to avoid favoritism, and to consider all sides. Sometimes, neutrality feels like courage. You’re resisting pressure from all sides. You’re above it all, right? But what most leaders call neutrality in moments of disagreement is not neutrality at all. It’s avoidance masquerading as virtue. It is what I think of as faux neutrality.

Faux neutrality is seductive. It solves a short-term emotional problem because when you stay silent in a tense moment, three things happen:

1. The tension in your own body drops.
2. The risk of immediate backlash usually decreases.
3. There isn’t any escalation.

The feeling of relief is powerful because it is real and leaders are human. They feel the anxiety when voices rise and they sense dread when meetings go off script. And, faux neutrality can offer a way to make all of that discomfort stop without having to jump in and take a stand that might anger someone. So, leaders begin to tell themselves stories. “I don’t want to escalate things”, “I don’t need to take sides”, “I want to be sure everyone is heard”, “I need to stay professional”, or even “I need to preserve trust”.

And each of those statements contains a kernel of truth. Yet, each of them quietly mislabels what is actually happening. It misses the fact that the leader is actively choosing their own short-term comfort over the long-term health of the institution. In the leader’s mind, they are not experiencing it that way. They are experiencing it as prudence.

“THERE IS NO GROWTH IN THE COMFORT ZONE” - JOCKO WILLINK

Jocko Willink and Leif Babin, both former Navy SEAL officers, talk about this in their book, *The Dichotomy of Leadership*. “There is no growth in the comfort zone”, says Jocko Willink, a mantra that SEAL leaders use to remind themselves and their teams that true leadership requires stepping into the hard places. SEAL training is widely regarded as some of the toughest on Earth. Not only do SEALs train for physical toughness, they train for mental toughness as well. Through the crucible of that training, SEALs are taught that comfort is the enemy of mission success. Leaders learn that avoidance, hesitation, and the instinct to stay comfortable reduce effectiveness and increase risk - which can be deadly in combat situations.

My purpose of talking about this concept is not to romanticize leadership as it relates to Navy SEAL training, but to point out that therein lies a structural truth about what leadership actually demands when under pressure. Leaders must actively **choose discomfort** repeatedly because it is the only way to shape outcomes, protect your teammates, and accomplish the mission. Comfort is surrendered at great cost. In combat, it can mean the loss of lives. In civilian leadership, discomfort signals the hard choices that must be made for the mission to succeed.

Each time a leader stays neutral in a moment that demands leadership, they are teaching the organization how power really works. Ever notice that people seem to be pretty good at reading behavioral patterns? They notice which complaints gain traction, which ones die silently, whose anger gets indulged, or whose dignity gets sacrificed. People also adapt to those patterns. They become quieter, more

cautious, more political, and more *performative*. It's not because they are cynical, but it is because they are paying attention.

Most leaders cling to faux neutrality because they believe it's the kind thing to do. They don't want to embarrass anyone or call them out. They don't want to create a scene. But kindness without boundaries isn't kindness at all. It's abdication. Because kindness protects the vulnerable, not the volatile. The person who needs protection in moments of escalation is almost never the one creating the noise. The volatile actor already has power and they are comfortable breaking the norms. They are willing to impose discomfort on others to get what they want. The vulnerable person is the one enforcing a rule, raising a concern, delivering unwelcome facts, or simply doing their job while being publicly diminished. And when leaders stay silent in times like these, the protection flows upward and outward towards the loudest voice in the room and not the person absorbing the harm. True kindness is not the refusal to intervene. It is the willingness to interrupt.

It says, "You do NOT get to do that here". Not to punish, but to protect. It restores dignity before it is stripped away. It draws a boundary line not to humiliate the aggressor, but to defend the culture, the process, and the people who are behaving *well*. If you fail to protect the vulnerable, you are not being neutral. You are teaching them that their dignity is conditional, and teaching the volatile that their behavior is effective. Intervening in moments like this feels unnatural at first. Your heart rate rises. Your voice feels heavier. You become aware that the entire room is watching. That discomfort is not a signal to retreat. It is a signal that leadership is required.

In my case with the volatile citizen, my mission was to protect process integrity and staff dignity. And my job was to interrupt harm immediately and not to wait to comment after

the fact. My obligation was to guard my staff against this type of attack. Hindsight is 20/20, they say. So, if you find yourself in a similar situation, follow these simple rules:

1. Interrupt immediately
2. Set the boundaries
3. Restore dignity

Excellent leadership (recall that this isn't what I did...) would have sounded something like this, "Sir, stop for a moment. Our staff member is enforcing a rule that applies equally to everyone. You do not get to speak to her that way in this room. Your time has expired. You may submit the remainder of your comments in writing. Please return to your seat". Then, to restore dignity, I could have looked at the Clerk and simply said, "Thank you for doing your job". That approach is effective for many reasons. There is no lecture, no moralizing, no escalation, no humiliation, and it's not *personal*. Just the business of showing authority, setting a boundary, and restoring order.

I say that it's "simple", but it's difficult to execute in the heat of the moment. Recall that I said, "The speaker must have a bitter heart...". It came from the right place - my heart - but it did several unintended things. The comment came *after* the harm instead of interrupting it. It described the speaker's character instead of correcting the behavior, which made it personal. And it did nothing to restore the dignity of the clerk in the moment she needed it. The room learned that the leadership in the room notices harm, but intervenes softly and late. Instead, it should have sounded like "Staff are protected here". We need to speak up, even when it's awkward. *Especially* when it's awkward.

Most leaders eventually learn this lesson, but they often learn it too late. They learn it because people leave, their meetings become dysfunctional, the culture becomes brittle, and authority erodes. Only then do they look back and realize

that there were moments that they could have shaped the conversation and set a new norm. Like the ghost of Scrooge in, “*A Christmas Carol*”, leaders are confronted with regret, recognition, and the slow realization that leaders carry these weights alone.

Typically, it’s not a salacious scandal or major crisis that brings most leaders to failure. They don’t just wake up one morning and realize that they’ve lost their authority in their organizations. They fail quietly. When they let moments pass and decide not to intervene, when silences are mistaken for professionalism, in choosing comfort over discomfort. For a long time, nothing obvious happens. Meetings happen, agendas move forward, everything looks stable, and the leader tells themselves that all is well. But the quiet truth is that they made hundreds of small mistakes - death by a 1,000 cuts. Moments like I had when a staff member was humiliated and I did not interrupt it. Or when misinformation was shared and not corrected. And, when one voice dominated and it was allowed to happen. Together, these small, seemingly minor issues, began to rewrite the culture.

When people begin to leave, or want to leave, the organization, leaders begin to sit up and take notice. That’s when the meetings become more difficult, the institution becomes brittle, and forward momentum ceases. People say things like, “The culture just changed.”, “Things got so political.”, “Trust was gone.”, or “The environment shifted.”. But it didn’t shift of its own. Leadership is responsible when responsibility is deferred, power goes unchallenged, or dignity is treated as optional. Instead of losing control of the organization, leaders are surrendering it one silence at a time.

Most leaders do not regret the hard conversations that they had. In fact, they regret the ones they avoided. The staff they didn’t protect, the processes they didn’t defend, or the moments they chose comfort over courage and called it

professionalism. And almost every experienced leader will tell you the same things, quietly, when no one else is listening. “I wish I had intervened earlier, drawn the line sooner, and realized that my silence was doing so much damage to our team.”.

There is a reframe that will help every leader end faux neutrality:

Silence is not the absence of leadership.
It is leadership with consequences.

This realization changes how leaders see every disagreement that follows. They stop asking whether they should intervene and start asking how and when. The remaining chapters of this book exist to answer that question.

Every moment of disagreement is not just an exchange. It is a lesson. And the leader, whether they intend it or not, is the instructor. So, stop asking “Should I get involved” and start asking three far more useful questions.

Question 1: What is being normalized right now?

When misinformation occurs and no one corrects it, something is being normalized. When a person is humiliated and no one interrupts, something is normalized. And when a boundary is crossed and no one responds, something is being normalized. The question isn’t whether or not the moment feels uncomfortable. The question is “If this happened tomorrow, would I want it to feel normal?”. Because that is what silence does. Every uncorrected lie trains the room that accuracy is optional, that dignity is negotiable, and that escalation works. The key is to intervene not because the moment is dramatic, but because the moment is instructional. Effective leaders understand that the culture is not shaped by speeches. It is shaped by interruptions.

Question 2: Who is absorbing the cost of my restraint?

This is the question that quickly clarifies what leadership requires. When a leader stays silent, someone else always pays. Maybe it's the staff member enforcing the rule, or the professional delivering unwelcome facts, the quieter voices being crowded out, or even the organization itself. Effective leaders ask, "Who is being left unprotected if I do nothing?". Because true kindness protects the vulnerable, not the volatile. The volatile person already has leverage and is comfortable imposing discomfort. They are NOT the ones at risk. The vulnerable person is the one behaving well and bearing harm quietly. And when leaders choose not to intervene, they are not being neutral. They are choosing who will carry the weight of the moment.

Question 3: Where will power move if I say nothing?

Power is like electricity. It never stays in the disagreement, it flows to and from those who are most willing to dominate it. Think to a time when you've been in a contentious meeting. Which voices dominated? The *loudest* voice, the *angriest* voice, the most *persistent* voice? These are the voices that often get the most recognition. The ones people gravitate towards. So, effective leaders learn to ask: "If I stay silent here, who becomes stronger because of it?". Because neutrality does not preserve trust, it redistributes it. And usually, it redistributes it away from process, roles, and principles and towards personalities.

When leaders begin to ask these questions consistently, something changes. They stop intervening emotionally and begin to intervene structurally. Not to win an argument, but to protect where authority is allowed to live.

In summary, in almost every moment that requires leadership, only three moves are needed:

Move One: Interrupt the behavior

Not the person, the behavior. Short. Calm. Direct.

“Can we stop for a moment?”

“That is not how we speak to one another here.”

“I need to correct that before we go further”

This isn't escalation, it's good leadership.

Move Two: Restore the norm

Name the rule, process, or value being protected.

“Our time limits apply to everyone.”

“We do not personalize disagreements in this room.”

“Facts matter here, even when they are inconvenient.”

That shifts the moment from personal conflict back to institutional order.

Move Three: Protect dignity and move on

Acknowledge the person who behaved well.

“Thank you for enforcing the rule.”

“I appreciate you raising that concern professionally.”

“Let's continue.”

Then, proceed. No lecture, no shaming, no performance. Just leadership.

Over time, effective leaders stop thinking about intervention as confrontation. They begin to see it as *maintenance*. Like reinforcing a beam before it cracks, or resetting tire alignment before the car begins to drift, or correcting posture before injury plaques the athlete. Effective leaders intervene early,

briefly, calmly, consistently. Not because they relish the idea of conflict, but because they understand something that most leaders learn too late: The cost of early discomfort is always lower than the cost of late repair.

I bet you're a bit like me and you realize that most leaders do not need more courage. They need a clearer rule. That simple rule is: If a moment is training the wrong lesson, lead. If dignity is being eroded, interrupt. If power is drifting towards bad behavior, redirect it. Because leadership is not measured by how calm you remain, it is measured by what becomes possible in the rooms you shape. Just as importantly, it becomes measured by what never becomes acceptable again.

Leadership Rule: If a moment is teaching the wrong lesson, leadership requires interruption.

What to Say Instead: "Let me correct that before we go further. I do not want the room to build a conclusion on inaccurate information."

CHAPTER 3: WHY SMART PEOPLE DISAGREE BADLY

If everyone here is intelligent, experienced, and well-intentioned...why does this still go so badly?

One of the most confusing realities of leadership is that disagreement quality has almost zero to do with intelligence. Some of the worst disagreements I have ever witnessed involved highly educated, very experienced, and objectively intelligent people. Attorneys, engineers, elected officials, top executives. People who can analyze complex financial or technical models, interpret laws, and make high-stakes decisions affecting thousands of lives. And yet, when disagreement entered the room, something changed. The conversation stopped being about truth and understanding and started being about *territory*. The positions hardened. Listening narrowed. Tones got sharper. And the goal quietly moved from understanding to *winning*.

It happened to me recently. After all, I am on this journey *with* you and mastery is an elusive mistress. I'm not perfect and I share with you the ups and downs of learning to effectively disagree. One of the most instructive disagreement failures that I've experienced did not begin with anger. It began with questions. Detailed questions.

During a public meeting, a board member began asking staff about specific financial line items. The line of questioning

was not about fiscal policy or broad strategy direction, but narrow questions about individual expenditures and timing differences. The questions were specific about reconciliation details and technical accounting treatment. And on the surface, the questions were legitimate. Financial oversight is one of the board's most important responsibilities. After all, organizational funds demand strict accountability and accountability requires inquiry.

But something began to change as the exchange wore on. Subtly, at first, then the questions became more granular, more persistent, and deafeningly public. There was an insinuation that money could not be accounted for and the Board Chair insisted there was a 'discrepancy' in our accounting with tens of thousands of missing dollars. Every answer from the staff was technically accurate and professionally delivered. The Finance Director explained the accounting and clarified procedural issues to help everyone understand the nuances with the issue at hand. But those answers did not resolve the questions from the Chair. They only generated more questions, culminating with a request to provide detailed line-item transaction-level accounting each month in a lengthy report to the board. The goal, it seems, was to have the Finance Director defend her competence in real-time, under public scrutiny, for decisions that were already correct.

The Chair was not unintelligent - quite the opposite. She was very analytical and accustomed to doing detailed research to prove a point. The questions were very precise. But precision, in the wrong structural environment, can unintentionally become pressure. And pressure changes how disagreement functions because the exchange stopped being about the information and started to become *positional*. Each additional question signaled to staff that the prior answers were insufficient. And each additional explanation became more defensive. Each moment began to shift the *emotional gravity* of the room - away from clarity and

towards uncertainty.

Even though nothing inappropriate was said, voices were not raised, and no rules were broken, the disagreement was no longer serving the goal of understanding. Confidence was being redistributed because staff began to feel that being correct was not sufficient to remain protected. Observers began to believe that authority could be publicly tested. Expertise alone does not stabilize disagreement - structure does. Because when disagreement becomes a public test of competence instead of a structured pursuit of understanding, even correct answers can weaken institutional trust.

I had a decision to make. I could allow the exchange to continue, trusting that technical answers would eventually resolve the concern. Or, I could intervene structurally. Not to stop the questions, but to stabilize the environment in which they were occurring. For a brief moment, I interrupted with an attempt to offer a standing meeting with the Chair, or any board member, who wished to review the financials and offered to bring detailed explanations to them. There was pushback from the Chair and a claim that she deserved any report she wished because, "I'm the *CHAIR*".

In that moment, I chose restraint and remained silent. I did not believe that continuing the engagement would lead to a different outcome. The Board Chair was fortified in her belief that this report contained data that she desperately needed to further understand or prove the financials correct or incorrect. My role in that moment was not to defend the content, but to protect the conditions under which the content could be trusted. And yet, I missed an opportunity to reinforce the framework that would have both protected the staff and the Chair. Effective leadership in that moment would have sounded something like this:

"I want to acknowledge the importance of these questions and the Finance Director's expertise in

answering them. These financial reports are prepared according to established accounting standards and are reviewed through multiple layers of internal and external oversight. If there are additional technical questions requiring deeper analysis, staff can provide that detail outside of this setting so we can ensure both accuracy and clarity. For now, I want to reinforce that our financial position and reporting remain sound and professionally managed.”

This would have accomplished three critical objectives simultaneously.

1. It would have affirmed the legitimacy of oversight.
2. It would have reinforced confidence in staff expertise.
3. It would have stabilized the structure of the disagreement.

Not because it would have *ended* the conversation, but because it would have *anchored* it. And that is the leader's role in moments like these. Not to win the disagreement, not to avoid the disagreement, but to hold the structure steady so the the disagreement does not erode the institution itself.

After that meeting, I spent a long time replaying the exchange in my mind. I rewatched the video feed and thought about what was said. Not the words, but the structure. The disagreement had not strengthened confidence. I couldn't help but think that if everyone involved was capable and professional, why had the interaction produced such instability instead of clarity?

The answer didn't reveal itself immediately. It happened over several days, slowly, through observations. Not just of that exchange, but of other meetings, public hearings, staff discussions, and executive briefings. All different people, different issues, different things at stake. But it was the same *pattern*. At some turning point in the exchange, the disagreement stopped functioning as a tool for

understanding and started functioning as a mechanism for protection. Each participant became more careful, more defensive, more invested in guarding their positions than examining them. Again, not because they lacked intelligence, but because something more powerful had takeover. The pattern began to become clear to me. Disagreement was not governed primarily by logic, but but three invisible forces:

1. Threat
2. Identity
3. Structure

These three forces exist in every disagreement. They are there just below the surface, influencing our behaviors whether we realize it or not. They don't announce themselves, nor do they ask permission - they just activate automatically. And once activated, they completely reshape the purpose of the interaction. If you understand how these forces work, you can begin to change how you approach disagreement because you can begin to recognize instability as it occurs and correct for it. Disagreement failure is not random, it's mechanical, and we have an entire toolkit to help us! Let's dive into each of the three forces and consider how we recognize each one.

Force One: Threat - Why the Brain Treats Disagreement Like Danger

When disagreement occurs, the brain does not interpret it as purely intellectual exchange. It interprets it as risk. A threat. Not necessarily physical, but a perceived threat. To credibility, to competence, to authority, and to belonging. And to understand why disagreement can destabilize even the most capable leaders, you have to understand how the brain responds to danger.

At the center of this threat response is a small, almond-shaped structure deep within the brain called the amygdala.

Some refer to the amygdala as our “reptilian brain”. A leftover from when humans roamed the earth hunting woolly mammoths and dwelling in caves. Cue the “Flintstones” theme music! Yabba dabba do!

But, the amygdala is what is responsible for what most people refer to as our “flight or fight” response. It is an early warning system whose sole purpose is survival. It continuously scans your environment for things that could indicate danger. And, when it detects a threat, it does not wait for careful analysis. It engages immediately, activating the body’s defensive systems before the rational brain has time to evaluate what is happening.

While that response is vitally important if you were to meet a saber-toothed tiger while gathering water by the riverside in prehistoric times, it does not always serve us well in modern-day office settings. Today, physical threats have been replaced with social threats. But to the amygdala, being publicly challenged and questioned repeatedly can feel remarkably similar to being physically endangered. After all, both situations carry the potential for loss. Loss of safety, loss of status, loss of belonging, loss of control.

And the brain dumps a flood of hormones into the bloodstream, namely cortisol and adrenaline, which elevate heart rate, respiration, and blood-sugar levels. Your muscles tense up, breathing becomes shallower, and your attention narrows to laser-like focus. The redirection of blood flowing to your prefrontal cortex portion of the brain (the “rational brain”) over to the amygdala complicates things even more and your body becomes a biological weapon. It’s no longer an intellectual issue, it’s primal.

Once this threat mechanism activates, the nervous system moves into one of four protective modes: fight, flight, freeze, and fawn. The kicker is that these happen automatically and are not conscious choices. They are just inherited survival

mechanisms that helped humans survive difficult environments and each one of them appears regularly in leadership disagreement.

The fight response attempts to neutralize the threat through confrontation. When we are in disagreement, this often appears as *escalation*. Our tones become sharper, arguments more rigid, we interrupt more frequently, and the focus shifts from resolution to dominance. We are no longer trying to understand the issue, we begin trying to overpower it. While it may not seem to be aggression in the traditional sense, it is a form of protection as the nervous system is attempting to restore safety by eliminating the uncertainty.

The flight response attempts to escape the threat by moving away from the conflict. In disagreement, this often appears as *avoidance*. Participants begin to withdraw, they speak less, defer decisions, and postpone resolution. We often see this as leaders delaying difficult conversations in the hopes that time will reduce tension. But avoidance does not resolve threat, it just preserves it for later. Unresolved disagreement remains structurally destabilizing long after the conversation ends.

The freeze response attempts to survive threat through *immobility*. During modern-day disagreements, this often appears as silence. Participants stop contributing and become passive observers, even deferring to others in spite of the fact that they may have important information. Leaders experiencing freeze may recognize that intervention is necessary, but feel momentarily unable to act. I want to be clear that this is **not** weakness. It's simply a neurological overload and the brain is prioritizing safety over action.

The fawn response attempts to neutralize threat through *appeasement*. In disagreements, this looks like participants agreeing prematurely. They soften their positions, avoid expressing disagreement entirely, and seek harmony. Not

because they are convince, but because they are trying to preserve safety. Fawn responses are particularly common among professionals who value institutional stability. But fawning and appeasement do not resolve disagreement, it buries it. Unresolved disagreement almost always resurfaces later in more destabilizing forms. You've likely experienced this yourself when you "go along to get along", only to be subjected to a real explosion later in the game.

Intelligence does not prevent these threat responses, but it does often disguise them. Heavily intelligent individuals may experience the same neurological threat activation but express it through sophisticated reasoning rather than obvious emotional reaction. Their arguments become more precise, their justifications more detailed, and their certainty more rigid. To the casual outside observer, this can show up as confidence. But it may just be protection as the nervous system works to restore a feeling of safety. This is why intelligent people can become so entrenched. Their cognitive ability strengthens their defensive capacity and their flexibility is diminished.

Understanding the amygdala and these threat responses changes how leaders interpret disagreements. It begins to reveal that destabilizing disagreement is not primarily a *character* issue, but a nervous system issue. The participants in a disagreement are not *choosing* defensiveness, they are *experiencing* it. And while it does not excuse harmful behaviors, it does explain it. More importantly, it clarifies the leader's responsibility. Effective leaders do not attempt to overpower threat responses, they stabilize the environment so threat responses do not active unnecessarily. They do this by reinforcing structure, clarity, and psychological safety. Because when the nervous system feels safe, the prefrontal cortex (the "rational brain") re-engages. This allows people to regain their capacity for reasoning, flexibility, and collaboration, making disagreements productive again. Not because the issues changed, because the environment did.

Force Two: Identity - Why Disagreement Stops Being About the Issue

If threat is what activates defensiveness, identity is what makes it persistent. Threat is immediate and physiological, but identity is deeper. It is psychological. Your identity is that internal story that you carry with you about *who you are*. And it tends to answer invisible by extremely powerful questions like:

Am I competent? Am I respected? Do I *belong* here? Am I trusted to lead?

Although these questions rarely surface consciously, they are shaping your behavior constantly. In leadership environments, identity becomes tightly wound with judgement. You've seen it a million times - leaders who are trusted become that way because they are perceived to make sound decisions. Their creditability is not just tied to what they do, it's tied to who they are or who they are believed to be. Over time, this becomes an identity that leaders begin to protect instinctively. And, it's where disagreement becomes dangerous. Because disagreement does not just challenges ideas, it challenges identity.

At the beginning of most disagreements, participants are focused on the issue itself. The numbers on the spreadsheet, the policy decisions, the recommendations to the board, etc. But at some point, the disagreement crosses an invisible line in the sand. The issue stops being separate from the person presenting it. Questions about the financial report begin to feel like a question about the Finance Director's competence. Challenges to a recommendation feel like a challenge to the leader's judgement. And disagreements about a leader's decision begin to feel like disagreements about the leader's fitness to lead.

No one announces the shift, it just happens internally as the brain begins a Vulcan mind meld exercise of merging the position of disagreement with the person delivering the message. At this point, any flexibility by either party becomes dangerous because changing position no longer feels like learning, it begins to feel like self-betrayal.

Most leaders don't land their roles by accident. Instead, they earn their positions through years of demonstrating competence. Their entire professional identity is built upon their ability to analyze situations, make decisions, and guide outcomes. Thus, their identity becomes reinforced over time and with various experiences. Eventually, the leader does not just make decisions, they become synonymous with the person who makes 'good' decisions and their identity becomes part of their psychological stability. Thus, when disagreements challenge one of their decisions, it does not just introduce new information, it brings with it instability. Not to the situation at hand, but to oneself. This is why intelligent, capable leaders can unexpectedly become rigid during disagreements. They aren't just defending the idea, they are protecting their identity as well.

Once identity becomes attached to position, disagreement enters a self-reinforcing loop. Leaders feel that their competence is being evaluated, which creates threat, which activates defensiveness, which strengthens commitment to the original positions. The stronger that commitment becomes, the more difficult it is to effectively change. Because changing now carries a real psychological cost and requires the leader to accept temporary instability in their own identity. And most people will not choose instability if they don't have to.

And this is where disagreement begins to break down. Not because people are *unwilling* to listen, but because listening begins to feel *dangerous*. You can watch it happen in real time: a simple question lands, the answer is given, and

another question follows. At some point, the person answering stops hearing those questions as curiosity and begins to hear them as *doubt*. And not doubt about the issue. Doubt about *them*. Once that happens, everything changes and the goal changes from trying to understand to trying to hold ground. It's not a failure of intelligence, but rather a protection of identity.

This monumental shift is rarely announced, but you can catch it if you know what to look for:

- The conversation becomes more rigid.
- People being repeating positions instead of exploring them.
- New information is treated as a threat instead of an input.
- Clarifying questions are seen as challenges.
- Small concessions feel disproportionately difficult.

No one is willing to say, "That's a great point.", because saying that no longer feels like learning. It feels like losing.

Most leaders see this moment and think, "I need to explain this better." So they add more detail, clarify again, defend their logic, and strengthen their argument. Which only seems to make the problem worse. Because when identity is involved, better arguments feel like stronger attacks. Leaders often unknowingly escalate the situation by cornering the other person's identity. When this happens, people cannot collaborate. Instead, they resist.

When this happens, it's imperative that leaders recognize it and work to separate the person from the position. Your job is not to push harder, but to create space again. To make it safe to think, adjust, and to be wrong without being diminished. This is not a 'soft' skill, this is precise leadership. You are not protecting feelings, you are protecting the conditions required for the truth to surface. While the concept is simple, execution requires some practice.

When identity is in play, your language must lower stakes without lowering standards. Some phrases that work well in this situation include:

- Would it be possible for us to separate the issue from the individual for a moment?
- Could it be possible for us to work through this without defending positions?
- If something needs to change here, then that's just part of getting it right.
- I want to be clear, this is not about anyone's capability. It's about making sure we are aligned on the outcome.
- We are not here to prove a point. We are here to get to the right answer.
- There is room here to adjust as we work through it. That is part of doing this well.
- Would you be open to bringing this back to the issue so we do not lose the value of the discussion?

These phrases lower perceived threat, reframe the purpose, and remove the penalty for flexibility. When this is well-executed, something subtle happens in the room. It exhales. People begin to think again instead of defend and the conversation returns to what it was supposed to be.

There is a hidden cost of ignoring identity. When leaders fail to manage identity in disagreement, two things happen:

- 1). The loud become louder
- 2). The thoughtful become quieter

Because thoughtful people will not compete in environments where being wrong carries a personal cost. They will simply opt out. And when they do, the organization loses its best thinking long before it loses its people. Disagreement rarely fails in the first exchange. It fails in the moment the issue becomes personal. When that line is crossed, intelligence

hardens, flexibility disappears, and progress slows. But leaders who understand identity don't get pulled into that shift. Instead, they recognize it, interrupt it, and they restore space where people can think clearly again. The goal of disagreement is not to protect your position, but to improve the outcome.

Force Three: Structure - Why the Environment Determines the Outcome

If identity explains why people dig in, structure explains whether the disagreement breaks down or holds together.

Structure is the least visible force in disagreement...and the most decisive. It answers questions most leaders never think to ask in the moment:

- Where is this conversation heading?
- Who is present?
- What is the purpose of this exchange?
- What is supposed to happen next?

Because, when structure is clear, disagreement has boundaries. When structure is weak, disagreement has *gravity* - it pulls everything into it.

In the board meeting scenario I described earlier, the issue was not just the financial questions. It was **where and how those questions were being asked** that mattered. Public meetings are designed for transparency, decision-making, and high-level accountability. They are **not** designed for real-time technical audits, prolonged cross-examinations, or rebuilding confidence line-item by line-item. Without intervention, structure can begin to drift.

What started as oversight slips into public pressure. What should have been clarification became performance. And what should be a controlled exchange became an open loop

without an end point. And once that happens, even correct answers begin to lose their power. Without structure, the truth doesn't feel like the truth at all. It feels like defense.

Structure does not usually collapse all at once. Rather, it erodes quietly. A question goes a bit too long; a follow-up becomes a challenge; or a clarification becomes a pattern. And nobody interrupts, resets, or pauses...and slowly the purpose of the conversation changes without anyone formally agreeing to it.

Most people feel this shift, but they misinterpret it. They think, "we need more detail...more explanation....more data". They mistakenly believe that if they just stay calm, everything will settle. So they add more content, more detail, more... defense. Unintentionally, they feed the instability until the train leaves the tracks. When structure is failing, content cannot save you.

You will feel structure failing before you can name it, but there will be signals:

- The conversation has no clear end point
- The same issue is being revisited without resolution
- Answers create more questions instead of clarity
- The exchange begins to feel performative
- The audience becomes as important as the outcome
- The conversation is no longer moving forward, it's swirling in circles.

You will then find yourself in a unique situation - you're no longer in disagreement - you are stuck in a loop. Loops have no resolution and it becomes important for leaders to recognize this and separate themselves from participation. To break a loop, you must interrupt it. The point is not to win the argument, it is about restoring forward movement. A leader must do something that feels unnatural in the moment and step out of the content and take control of the structure.

Leaders can do this by the following methods:

1). Name the pattern - "We are starting to revisit the same ground."

This does two things immediately. It makes the invisible visible and it gives the room permission to recognize what is happening.

2). Clarify the objective - "What would need to be true for this to be settled?"

This shifts the conversation from repetition to purpose. Because most loops exist for one reason: no one has defined what 'done' looks like.

3). Redirect the path. Depending on the situation:

If more information is needed: "Let's capture the remaining questions and bring back a clear, complete answer."

If the issue has been sufficiently addressed: "We have answered this from a technical standpoint. At this time, we need to decide whether to auction that or move in a different direction."

If the setting is wrong: "This level of detail is important, but this is not the setting where it can be worked through effectively".

And then? You move on. Not abruptly and not dismissively, but *decisively*. Because the goal is not to satisfy every repetition, but to protect the integrity of the process.

Most leaders believe disagreement fails because of people, but that is rarely the case. It fails because no one protects the structure. Without structure, threat escalates, identify

hardens, and authority drifts. This allows the loudest voices in the room to become the most influential. Not because they are right, but because they are persistent.

At first glance, disagreement looks unpredictable: different people, different personalities, different stakes. But underneath the surface, there is a distinct pattern: threat activates, identity attaches, and structure begins to drift. And once those three forces are in motion, the outcome is no longer driven by logic, it's driven by emotional conditions.

This is why smart people disagree badly! Not because they lack intelligence or experience. It's because they are operating inside conditions that make good thinking difficult. And this is where leaders can shine. You stop asking, "Why is this happening?", and start asking, "What is happening to the environment right now?". This question changes everything. Because you begin to see the moment before it breaks. You notice when answers start getting longer instead of clearer, when positions begin to harden, and when the conversation begins to circle instead of moving forward. Instead of reacting to the disagreement, you begin to **lead** it.

You slow the momentum down before it escalates, you separate the issues from the person before identity locks in, and you restore structure before the conversation begins to drift. You don't have to do this step perfectly, but you must do it with intentionality. Most leaders do not fail in disagreement because they make one catastrophic mistake, they fail because they miss the moment when disagreement changes and stops being about the issue. That moment is rarely loud. It shows up quietly. In a tone, in a question, in a shift in posture. And if you miss it, you spend the rest of the conversation trying to recover something that has already moved. But if you can see it, you can lead it.

There is a point in every disagreement where everything you've just read becomes real. It's not the beginning of the conversation, nor the end. It's the moment where threat activates, identity attaches, and structure begins to drift. Most leaders miss the turning point because they are focused on the content instead of the shift. Chapter 4 is about that moment and what to do when you stop reacting to disagreement and start shaping what happens next.

Leadership Rule: Disagreement does not break all at once. It breaks in moments. If you can recognize the moment, you can change the outcome.

What to Say Instead: "Let me correct that before we go further. I do not want the room to build a conclusion on

CHAPTER 4: THE MOMENT THAT MATTERS MOST

What's the exact moment in your career where you now realize... 'that's where I lost the room'?

Earlier in this book, I told the story of a public meeting early in my career where I lost the room almost instantly. At the time, I believed the problem was that I had chosen the wrong words. Sixteen years later, I realize the problem was deeper than language alone.

I misunderstood the moment.

When I stood at the podium and asked, "Where were you when we developed this plan?", I believed I was defending the integrity of the process. Technically, the question was fair. The recommendation aligned with the adopted plan. The public had opportunities to participate. From a procedural standpoint, the logic was sound.

But leadership is not only about procedural accuracy. It is about emotional awareness.

The people in that room were not evaluating whether the request matched the plan. They were evaluating whether they felt heard, respected, and understood in a moment that felt deeply personal to them. I answered a procedural question while the room was asking an emotional one.

That was the moment I lost them.

It was not a scandal, a shouting match, or some catastrophic leadership failure splashed across headlines. It was a sentence. A single sentence delivered in the wrong tone, at the wrong moment, with the wrong understanding of what the room actually needed from me. And I have spent the last sixteen years learning how much damage one poorly chosen sentence can do.

The request itself appeared straightforward. The proposal aligned with the Town's recently adopted Comprehensive Plan, a document shaped through months of public meetings, workshops, and citizen input. From my perspective as a young planner, the recommendation made sense procedurally, technically, and legally.

That confidence became part of the problem.

When the public hearing began, the room filled quickly. Neighbors packed the chambers. The opposition was emotional, loud, and deeply personal. People feared traffic, noise, and change. Some worried about property values. Others worried about losing the character of the community they loved. One resident said, "Our whole town is going to smell like chicken." Another warned about schoolchildren crossing traffic to get food after school.

At the time, I heard exaggeration. I heard inconsistency. I heard people objecting to something that matched the very plan they had previously supported. And when I stepped to the podium that night, I believed my job was to defend the recommendation. I did not yet understand that my real job was to stabilize the room.

I still remember the feeling. My palms were sweaty, knees weak, arms heavy. Wait....that reminds me of an Eminem song. But, I digress. In that moment, my heart was racing. I was young, technically prepared, and absolutely convinced the facts were on my side. So I asked the question that, on

paper, probably sounded reasonable: “Where were you when we were developing this plan?”

Technically, it was a fair question. Leadership-wise, it was a disaster.

Because what the room heard was not, “Help me understand the disconnect.” What they heard was, “You had your chance. Your concerns no longer matter.”

That was the turning point.

Not because the citizens suddenly disagreed with planning principles. Not because the recommendation changed. Not because the Comprehensive Plan became invalid. I lost the room because I failed to recognize what kind of moment it actually was.

The citizens in that room did not need a lecture on process. They needed acknowledgment. They needed someone to recognize that even when growth is technically appropriate, change can still feel deeply personal. They needed empathy before explanation. Instead, I gave them correction before connection.

I was trying to win the argument. They were trying to protect something they loved. Those are not the same conversation.

That night taught me something I did not fully understand at the time: people can reject your conclusion simply because they reject how you made them feel while you delivered it. Leaders often assume disagreement turns on information. Most of the time, it turns on emotional interpretation. Underneath almost every disagreement are invisible questions people are asking themselves:

Do you respect me?
Do you hear me?

Do I matter in this process?

Are you trying to understand me, or simply manage me?

If those questions get answered poorly, the content almost stops mattering.

That does not mean facts are unimportant. Facts matter deeply. Process matters. Expertise matters. Plans matter. But human beings rarely process difficult information in a purely rational order. Emotion arrives first. Meaning arrives second. Logic usually arrives last.

I learned that lesson the hard way.

For years afterward, that meeting followed me. Not because citizens remembered every detail of the case, but because moments like that create reputations. People may forget the specifics of what you said, but they remember how you made the room feel.

And the painful part is that I was not trying to be arrogant. I was trying to defend the integrity of the process. But intent does not erase impact.

That realization fundamentally changed how I began thinking about disagreement. Over time, I started noticing something important in public meetings, leadership conversations, and difficult interactions: the moment that matters most is rarely the loudest one. It is the turning point. The instant where the room decides whether you are trying to help people through tension or defeat them inside it.

Once that turn happens, everything becomes harder. Questions sound sharper. Clarifications feel defensive. Trust erodes faster. People stop listening for understanding and begin listening for threat. Leaders often respond by adding more information. More slides. More data. More explanation.

More facts. But once people feel dismissed, additional information often sounds like additional indifference.

The problem was never the data. The problem was the emotional contract.

Looking back now, I realize there was another way to handle that meeting. Not by abandoning the recommendation, apologizing for the planning process, or surrendering professional judgment. Leadership does not require abandoning expertise. But it does require understanding that people can feel fear, grief, frustration, or uncertainty even when the recommendation itself is technically sound.

If I could walk back into that room today, I would begin very differently. I would acknowledge what people were feeling before trying to persuade them what to think. I would recognize that the public was not simply reacting to what I considered a standard request. They were reacting to the fear of losing familiarity, identity, and control over the place they called home.

I might say something like this:

“I want to acknowledge something before we discuss the technical merits of this request. I can hear that many of you are worried about what this change means for your neighborhood and for the future character of the community. Those concerns are real, even when people may disagree about the outcome. Part of our responsibility tonight is to weigh those concerns honestly against the adopted plan and the long-term vision the Town has established. My goal is not to dismiss your concerns. It is to help us work through them carefully and respectfully.”

Notice what changed.

The recommendation did not change. The process did not change. The facts did not change. But the posture changed completely. One posture said, You are wrong. The other said, I understand why this feels important to you.

That distinction changes everything.

Because effective disagreement is not about surrendering truth. It is about creating enough safety for truth to actually be heard. Most leaders believe they will recognize the moment disagreement becomes dangerous because they are expecting something dramatic. Raised voices. Anger. Open hostility. Someone slamming a hand on the table or storming out of the room. But most disagreement does not break that way.

It breaks quietly.

The shift usually begins long before the room becomes openly combative. In fact, some of the most damaging disagreement I have ever witnessed happened in rooms that remained perfectly professional on the surface. No yelling. No profanity. No obvious loss of control. Everyone still speaking calmly while trust quietly drained from the room like air escaping a tire.

That is what makes these moments so dangerous. Leaders often miss them because they are listening to the content while the emotional structure underneath the conversation is already changing.

Over time, I began noticing that disagreement almost always gives signals before it fully deteriorates. The room begins to change character. The purpose of the interaction shifts. And if you know what to look for, you can often recognize the turn before the damage becomes irreversible.

There are four signals I now watch for constantly.

Signal One: Questions Stop Sounding Curious

Healthy disagreement is fueled by curiosity. People ask questions because they are trying to better understand the issue, the risk, the process, or the reasoning behind a recommendation. Even difficult questions can feel constructive when curiosity is still present.

But eventually, in unhealthy disagreement, the emotional tone of the questions begins to shift.

The questions become sharper. More repetitive. Less exploratory. Instead of opening space, they begin narrowing it. The purpose quietly changes from understanding to proving. Questions stop functioning like bridges and start functioning like spotlights.

You can feel the difference almost immediately.

A curious question sounds like:

“Help me understand how you arrived at that conclusion.”

A positional question sounds like:

“So you’re saying nobody thought this through before tonight?”

One seeks clarity. The other seeks leverage.

And here is the important part: the words themselves are not always dramatically different. Sometimes the shift happens entirely through tone, pacing, repetition, or context. That is why leaders who only listen for factual content often miss the turn completely.

Once questions stop sounding curious, the room begins moving toward performance instead of understanding. Participants stop listening to answers with openness and

begin listening selectively for weakness, contradiction, or opportunity. The disagreement is no longer functioning as collaborative problem-solving. It has become positional.

This is the moment where many leaders make a critical mistake. They assume the solution is more explanation. So they answer longer. They provide more data, more context, more detail, and more defense.

But when curiosity disappears, additional information rarely restores trust. It often deepens the instability because the disagreement is no longer informational at its core.

The issue underneath the issue has changed.

Effective leaders learn to slow the room down at this point instead of accelerating into explanation. Sometimes the best leadership move is not answering faster. It is clarifying the purpose of the exchange itself.

That can sound like:

“I want to make sure we are still working toward understanding here and not simply repeating positions.”

Or:

“Before we continue, let’s clarify what concern we are ultimately trying to resolve.”

Those kinds of statements do something important psychologically. They interrupt the emotional momentum before the disagreement fully hardens into opposition. They shift the room from reaction back toward reflection.

Most people do not realize how quickly a room can reorganize itself emotionally once curiosity disappears. The conversation may still look productive from the outside, but

underneath it, people have already stopped trying to learn from one another. They are simply waiting for their next turn to defend, challenge, or persuade.

And once that happens, the disagreement becomes much harder to recover.

Signal Two: Answers Stop Creating Clarity

One of the clearest signs that disagreement is turning unhealthy is when answers stop reducing tension.

In healthy disagreement, good answers create movement. People may not fully agree, but the conversation progresses. Clarifications narrow uncertainty. Facts create direction. Even when disagreement remains, participants begin building shared understanding around the issue itself.

But when a room begins to turn, something different happens.

Every answer creates another question.
Every clarification produces another suspicion.
Every explanation becomes evidence that more explanation is required.

The conversation begins looping instead of progressing.

This is one of the most exhausting experiences a leader can face because it creates the illusion that resolution is always one more answer away. Leaders begin believing that if they can just explain the issue more clearly, organize the facts more carefully, or provide enough supporting detail, the tension will finally settle.

But when answers stop creating clarity, the issue is usually no longer the issue.

At that point, the disagreement has often shifted into something emotional, symbolic, or identity-based. The facts may still matter, but they are no longer carrying the full emotional weight of the interaction. People are now reacting not only to the information itself, but to what the information represents to them.

This happens constantly in leadership.

A budget discussion stops being about numbers and becomes about trust. A personnel disagreement stops being about performance and becomes about respect, fairness, or authority.

And because leaders are trained to solve problems, they instinctively keep feeding the room more information. Unfortunately, information cannot resolve emotional distrust by itself.

I learned this lesson painfully over time. There were moments where I walked out of meetings convinced I had explained something accurately and thoroughly, only to realize later that accuracy was not the real deficit in the room. Emotional confidence was.

People were not asking:
“Do I understand this?”

They were asking:
“Do I trust the people telling me this?”

That is an entirely different problem.

Once answers stop creating clarity, leaders must stop focusing exclusively on content and begin paying attention to conditions. Is the room still emotionally capable of processing information productively? Or has the conversation shifted into a cycle of suspicion, defensiveness, and repetition?

The longer leaders fail to recognize this shift, the more exhausting the disagreement becomes for everyone involved. Participants begin speaking past one another. Trust erodes. Confidence weakens. And eventually, the conversation becomes less about resolution and more about endurance.

That is usually the moment where leadership is required most.

Signal Three: The Audience Enters the Conversation

One of the clearest signs that disagreement is beginning to deteriorate is when the audience becomes as important as the outcome itself.

At first, people are speaking to each other. They are trying to exchange information, resolve concerns, test assumptions, or move toward some kind of shared understanding. But once the room begins to turn, the interaction subtly changes. Participants stop talking to one another and begin talking through one another.

The audience has entered the disagreement.

This happens constantly in modern leadership environments because almost every disagreement now has the potential to become public performance. Meetings are livestreamed. Conversations are clipped into short videos. Social media rewards outrage, certainty, and conflict far more than nuance or restraint. The incentive structure has changed. Visibility often produces more emotional reward than resolution.

Once an audience becomes psychologically present in the disagreement, behavior changes quickly.

People begin protecting image instead of pursuing understanding. Statements become sharper and more absolute. Questions become less about learning and more about signaling. Concessions become dangerous because flexibility can look like weakness in front of spectators. And suddenly the disagreement is no longer just about the issue itself. It becomes about identity, positioning, and public perception.

This is why some disagreements seem impossible to resolve publicly even when the actual issue is relatively manageable privately. The audience changes the emotional economics of the conversation. People begin performing for approval instead of working toward clarity.

I have seen this happen in board rooms, executive meetings, community forums, and online spaces countless times. Someone begins speaking not to persuade the person across from them, but to earn affirmation from the people behind them. Their real audience is no longer the room itself. It is the future social media post, the ally waiting to repost the clip, the supporter looking for confirmation, or the crowd waiting for a villain.

That shift is incredibly destabilizing because performance rewards escalation. Calmness feels weak. Nuance feels unsatisfying. Certainty becomes more valuable than accuracy. And once that happens, disagreement starts drifting away from governance and toward theater.

This does not mean public accountability is bad. Transparency matters deeply, as trust depends upon openness. But there is a significant difference between transparency and performance. Transparency seeks understanding. Performance seeks emotional reaction.

Effective leaders learn to recognize the difference quickly.

You can often spot the moment the audience enters the disagreement because participants stop responding directly to what was said. Instead, they begin delivering statements designed to land emotionally with observers. The conversation becomes less responsive and more scripted. People begin repeating talking points instead of engaging substance. The disagreement starts generating heat without producing movement.

This is the moment where leaders must resist the temptation to join the performance themselves. That is difficult because performance is contagious. Escalation invites escalation. Emotion invites emotion. Public pressure invites defensive positioning.

But leaders who become performers inside disagreement almost always lose their ability to stabilize the room.

The leader's job is not to out-perform the loudest voice. The leader's job is to restore conditions where thoughtful disagreement can still occur. That often means slowing the emotional tempo down instead of matching it.

Sometimes that sounds like:

"I want to make sure we are solving the issue in front of us and not simply reacting to frustration around it."

Or:

"I think it would help us to move away from assumptions and come back to the specific decision we are being asked to make."

These statements do not suppress disagreement. They redirect it away from spectacle and back toward structure.

Because once disagreement becomes performance, truth itself often becomes secondary to emotional momentum.

And emotional momentum is very difficult to govern once it takes over a room.

Signal Four: The Issue Becomes Identity

The final signal is usually the most dangerous because it is the point where disagreement stops feeling external and starts feeling personal.

At the beginning of most disagreements, people are discussing ideas, decisions, recommendations, or concerns. There is still separation between the individual and the position being debated. But once the room fully turns, that separation begins to collapse. The issue becomes identity.

A disagreement about a recommendation begins feeling like a judgment about competence. A challenge to an idea begins feeling like a challenge to credibility. Questions begin feeling like accusations. Disagreement begins feeling like rejection. This is the moment where flexibility disappears. Because once identity attaches itself to a position, changing course no longer feels like learning. It feels like losing. It feels humiliating. Threatening. Unsafe.

This is why intelligent, experienced, and otherwise reasonable people can suddenly become rigid during disagreement. It is not always because they are arrogant or unwilling to listen. Often, it is because their nervous system no longer experiences the disagreement as informational. It experiences it as existential.

The room changes immediately when this happens. People stop exploring and begin defending. They repeat themselves instead of processing new information. Small concessions become emotionally difficult. Clarifying questions are

interpreted as attacks and participants begin listening for threat instead of understanding. And perhaps most importantly, nobody feels safe being wrong anymore. That is one of the most dangerous conditions any organization can create.

Because once people fear being wrong publicly, thoughtful disagreement begins disappearing entirely. The loud often become louder while the thoughtful become quieter. The organization slowly loses its ability to self-correct because people begin protecting themselves instead of challenging weak ideas. This is why leaders must learn to separate people from positions before identity fully locks in. The goal is not to eliminate disagreement. The goal is to preserve enough emotional safety for people to think clearly while disagreement occurs. That requires language that lowers threat without lowering standards.

Leaders who understand this stop speaking as though disagreement is a moral contest to be won. Instead, they begin reinforcing shared purpose and shared humanity inside the disagreement itself.

That can sound like:

“Let’s separate the issue from the individual for a moment.”

Or:

“This conversation is not about anyone’s value or competence. It is about making sure we fully understand the issue before moving forward.”

Or even:

“There is room here for adjustment without anyone losing credibility.”

Those kinds of statements create space for flexibility to return. They reduce the emotional penalty for reconsideration. And when people no longer feel personally cornered, the conversation often begins breathing again.

Most leaders think disagreement becomes dangerous when people become emotional. That is not quite true. Disagreement becomes dangerous when people stop feeling psychologically safe enough to think. That is the real turning point. And the leaders who recognize it earliest are usually the ones most capable of stabilizing the room before the disagreement fully breaks apart.

By the time all four of these signals appear together, the room has usually shifted from collaboration into protection. Questions stop sounding curious. Answers stop creating clarity. The audience enters the disagreement. The issue becomes identity. Once that happens, the conversation is no longer moving naturally toward resolution. It is moving toward escalation, exhaustion, or fracture unless someone intentionally intervenes.

That is the work of leadership.

Not controlling disagreement.

Not suppressing tension.

Not winning the exchange.

Stabilizing the conditions so disagreement can still produce truth instead of damage.

Leadership Rule: People are not only judging your answer, they are judging whether you understand the question beneath it.

What to Say Instead: "Before I explain the decision, I want to make sure I understand what this means for you."

CHAPTER 5: QUESTIONS THAT CHANGE THE POWER DYNAMIC

Phil M. Jones, in his book *Exactly What to Say*, explains that one of the four cornerstones to great conversations is that, “the person asking the questions controls the conversation.” In a hardening disagreement, leaders often default to either answering questions being asked or defending their position. But a well-placed question moves the power in the room without anyone losing face. Over the years, I’ve found that there are four main question types: diagnostic questions, ownership questions, structural questions, and reframing questions. We will explore each of these more.

Diagnostic Questions: Finding the Question Beneath the Question

Most disagreements are not actually about the question being asked. They dance around *the question* beneath the question. A board member drilling down into line-item accounting is rarely just asking about accounting. A citizen objecting to a drive-thru restaurant is rarely just objecting to fast food. Somewhere beneath the surface question is the real one: *Do I trust the process? Am I being taken seriously? Is something being hidden from me?*

Leaders who miss this spend their energy answering the wrong question, extremely well. They get more precise, more detailed, more accurate, and provide heaps more data - and the room gets no calmer. That is because accuracy, transparency, and data was never the deficit. Diagnostic

questions exist to find out what the deficit actually is before you spend another breath defending your answer.

Think of every contentions exchange as having two layers. The top layer is the stated concern. The one you *hear* them claiming to be the real issue: the numbers, the policy, the decision, the timeline, etc. The bottom layer is what is at stake *emotionally*. Things like trust, fairness, belonging, control, fear of being blindsided, etc. Most leaders respond quickly to the top layer because it's the one that got said out loud. But the bottom layer is the one actually driving the conversation. A diagnostic question is simply a tool for shedding some light on which layer you are actually standing in.

You will know you have found the *real question* when the tone in the room shifts before the content does. People will begin to soften; they will stop repeating themselves; and sometimes they will go quiet for a beat. They go quiet because they were not expecting to be asked what they actually needed, only what they were prepared to argue about.

Diagnostic questions sounds like:

“Is the concern about the numbers themselves, or about how confident we can be in them going forward?”

- “Could you help me understand what would feel like a complete answer here?”
- “Is this about this decision specifically, or a broader concern about how decisions like this get made?”
- “When you say this doesn’t feel right, what part of it doesn’t feel right?”

- “What’s the outcome you’re concerned about if this goes forward the way it’s currently written?”
- “Is there something that happened before this conversation that’s shaping how this feels right now?”

Notice what these all have in common. None of them actually defends a position and none of them actually add any information at all. They introduce a pause in the exchange just long enough to locate the actual disagreement, which is often one layer beneath the one being argued.

This works the same way whether the room is a city council chamber, in a non-profit board meeting, or in a hospital conference room. A physician pushing back hard on a new pay policy may be arguing about bonus pay ratios on the surface, while underneath the real concern is whether patient safety is being deprioritized for efficiency. A diagnostic question gets to that in one sentence instead of three meetings.

A word of caution: diagnostic questions only work if they are asked with *genuine curiosity*. Asked flatly, as if from a script, they will come across as condescending, as though the leader is implying the other person doesn’t know their own concern. The *tone* has to carry the same message as the words: *I am trying to understand you, not manage you.*

If the Finance Director in Chapter 3 had been given room to ask something like the first example instead of simply supplying more transaction detail, the exchange might have surfaced that the Chair’s real concern was being blindsided by the future numbers and being criticized by the public for not understanding the budget. That is a solvable problem. An open-ended demand for more data is not.

Diagnostic questions locate the real disagreement. Once you know what it actually is, the next challenge is getting both

sides to agree on what solving it would even look like. That is where ownership questions come in.

Ownership Questions: Moving From Who's Right to 'What's Next'

Once identity attaches to a position, as we saw in Chapter 3, being wrong stops feeling like *learning* and begins to feel like *losing*. No amount of better arguing will ever fix that, because the problem is no longer the argument. It's the psychological cost of changing position in front of witnesses.

Ownership questions work little differently. Instead of asking who has the better case, they ask everyone in the room to describe what a resolved outcome would actually look like. That shift is small on paper and significant in practice, because it does people from defending the past to creating the future. You cannot defend a position and describe a shared outcome in the same sentence. That is because the two require different postures, and the question forces the second one.

There is a reason this works better than it sounds like it should. Most disagreements never define what "done" means. People argue as though winning the exchange is the goal, without ever agreeing on what winning actually looks like or would produce. An ownership question exposes that gap almost immediately. Sometimes the honest answer is, "I don't know," which is itself useful information. It tells you the disagreement was never really about the stated issue. It was about not feeling heard, and not outcome was going to satisfy that until the feeling was addressed.

Ownership questions sound like:

- "What would need to be true for you to consider this settled?"

- “If we solve this well, what does that actually look like six months from now?”
- “What outcome are we both trying to protect here?”
- “If you and I agreed on everything else but this one piece, what would that piece need to include?”
- “What would make this feel like a fair process, regardless of which way the decision goes?”
- “A year from now, what would tell you that this was handled the correct way?”

These questions work because they are almost impossible to answer defensively. Nobody digs in harder when asked to describe success - they soften. That is because the questions assumes good faith on both sides rather than assigning blame to one. It also quietly does something else: it puts the responsibility for defining “done” back on the room, instead of leaving the lever the sole arbiter of when the disagreement is over.

A school principal fielding an upset parent’s meeting about a discipline decision can use the same tool a corporate VP use with a direct report who feels passed over for a promotion: “What would need to happen here for you to feel like this was handled fairly, even if the outcome doesn’t change?” The question does not promise a different outcome. It promises a different process, and often that is the than that is actually being asked for.

Ownership questions have a failure mode worth discussing. If you ask what resolution looks like and then ignore the answer, you have done way more damage than if you had never even asked. The question only works if you are prepared to take the answer seriously, even when you cannot fully deliver on it. If you cannot, say so directly. “I hear that

you need X. I may not be able to give you all of that, but here's what I can do." That is still more honest than asking a good question and then quietly shelving the answer.

Ownership questions work when a room can still see a road ahead. But some disagreements stop moving entirely. They just circle. That is an entirely different problem, and it needs a different tool.

Structural Questions: Naming the Loop Before It Names You

In Chapter 3, we called this a loop: that conversation that keeps circling because nobody has defined what "resolved" means, so every answer produces another question instead of progress. In Chapter 4, we described the same pattern from the other side: where answers stop creating clarity, and the exchange starts feeling like defense instead of dialogue. Structural questions exist to interrupt that pattern without shutting the conversation down. They do not try to win the point still being argued. They step outside the content entirely and ask what the conversation is actually for.

I'll admit. This is the hardest type of question to use well, because it requires you to admit, out loud, that the conversation has stopped functioning the way that it should. That admission feels risky in the moment, but it rarely hits that way. Naming the loops almost never received as a weakness, rather it is usually received as relief. That's because everyone in the room has already felt the conversation spinning out of control. Someone simply needed to say it out loud.

Structural questions sound like:

- "What decision are we actually here to make right now?"

- “Are we still working toward a resolution, or are we revising ground we’ve already covered?”
- “What’s the one thing that would need to happen for us to move forward from here?”
- “Are we solving a problem right now, or processing frustration about it? Both matter, but they need different amounts of time.”
- “Is there new information on the table, or are we restating what we already know?”
- “What would it look like for us to table this piece and come back to it with fresh eyes?”

The mechanism behind this is quite simple. A loop survives on momentum and as long as the conversation keeps moving, even in circles, everyone assumes progress is being made somewhere underneath the repetition. A structural question breaks that illusion by naming the *shape* of the conversation instead of its *content*. Once the room sees the loop, it is hard for the loop to continue unacknowledged.

Timing matters here more than with the other three types of questions. Used too early, a structural question can feel dismissive, as though you are cutting off a concern before it has been fully heard. Used at the right moment, usually after the second or third repetition of the same point in different words, it feels like *exactly* what the room needed. A rough test you can use in the moment: if you could summarize the last three exchanges in a single sentence without losing anything, you are in a loop...and it’s time to name it.

This tool travels well across settings because loops themselves are not industry-specific. A corporate VP watching the same budget objection resurface in its third meeting, a law partner stuck in a recurring disagreement with

their managing partner over staffing models, or a city manager caught in a council meeting that keeps circling back to the same unresolved concerns. All are dealing with the same structural problem, and all three can use the same tool to interrupt it.

Naming a loop works when everyone in the room is arguing in good faith, it's just not getting anywhere. But not every question is asked in good faith. Some are built to trap you. Those need their own response.

Reframe Questions: Handing the Question Back Without Defending

Ever been in a disagreement and gotten *that* question? You know, the one that isn't really a question at all. Rather, it's just a challenge dressed up as an inquiry, built to provoke a defense rather than an answer. I'm reminded of the old cop TV shows where the agent asks the husband, "When did you start beating your wife?"

In Chapter 3, we described the nervous system's fight response as an attempt to neutralize threat through confrontation. A leader who takes every positional question ask face value and tries to answer it directly is often walking straight into that dynamic, absorbing an attack as though it were a request for information.

Reframing questions offer a way out that is neither combative nor submissive. They do not ignore the challenge, but they do not accept its framing either. Instead, they ask the other person to convert the challenges into something specific enough to actually be answered. This does something subtle, but important. It returns the burden of clarity to the person who raised the concern, without ever telling them that their concern doesn't matter.

Reframing questions sound like:

- “Can you help me turn that into a specific question I can answer directly?”
- “What information would actually help us solve this?”
- “Are we asking whether this was handled correctly, or whether it should be handled differently going forward?”
- “Could it be possible to explain what you’re seeing that’s leading you to this conclusion? I want to make sure I’m responding to the right thing.”
- “If I answered that fully right now, then what would you need to hear in the answer?”
- “That sounds like more than one concern. Which one matters the most right now?”

None of these dodge the issue. They simply refuse to accept a vague or loaded version of it. Positional questions thrive on ambiguity, because that lets the challenger stay one step removed from having to specify what they actually want. Asking for that specificity, calmly and without irritation, often does more to defuse the moment than any answer could.

There is a particular kind of positional question that this tool is built for. That is the one that is designed to make you defend something that you never said, or to force you into a idea that you don’t actually accept.

“So, you’re saying this doesn’t matter?”, is one of the most common forms of this question. I

Answering it directly, *“No, that’s not what I’m saying.”*, only keeps you inside a box that someone else built for you. A reframing question steps outside the box instead of arguing within it.

“I want to make sure I understand the actual concern before I respond to what you think I”m saying”, is one way to reframe such a question.

The trick here is that tone carries almost all of the weight. Words delivered flatly can sound evasive, while delivered with genuine openness, they sound exactly like what they are - an invitation to get specific. This is the one question type most likely to backfire if it is used as a shield rather than at a genuine attempt at clarity, so it works best paired with real follow-through. Once the person gives you something specific, answer it fully and directly. The reframe earns its credibility by what happens immediately after it.

Four tools to help you navigate the power dynamic. Diagnostic to locate the real Conner, ownership to define what resolved looks like, structural to break the loop, and reframe to defuse the loaded question. Each one is simple to describe, but much harder to read for in the heat of the moment. Here is what it costs when none of them get used.

Case Study: When Oversight Feels Like an Attack

A board member raises a series of concerns privately with the town’s chief executive: an outside attorney’s emails on matters the board wasn’t informed about, a rezoning process that they don’t feel is transparent, and a request for contracts in the name of ‘financial oversight’.

The executive doesn’t answer the questions directly, but instead asks, “Do you trust me?”. The board member says, “No”. “Okay”, the executive says. “I don’t trust you either. Now that we’ve gotten that out of the way, let’s talk about how we move forward - *together*.”

What follows is a back-and-forth where the executive makes the case that the trust problem runs both directions, pointing

to things the board member has done that damaged the relationship just as much as anything the executive is being accused of. Eventually, the executive offers to meet one-on-one weekly to help rebuild the relationship. The board member eventually declines any further dialogue in an email a few days later.

This case study is not a story about an executive who avoided the real issue. To their credit, they named it. Trust was, in fact, the actual problem underneath the line item reviews and the records requests. That is more than most leaders manage in the moment.

But naming the right issue and handling it well are two different skills, and this where all four tools we describe in this chapter could have changed the outcome.

“Do you trust me?” Is a closed question. It asks for a verdict and not an exploration. A Diagnostic Question would have gone looking for the specific thing driving the distrust instead: “What would help you feel confident in how these decisions are being made going forward.”

Responding to “no” with “I don’t trust you either” turns a shared problem into a scorecard. Once both people are counting grievances, neither one can concede anything without losing ground. An Ownership Question would have redirected that energy toward the future instead of the ledger: “What would need to be true for you to feel confident this is being handled well, regardless of who’s right about how we got here?”

Offering weekly meetings was a structural move, but it arrived without a foundation underneath it. Nobody had agreed on what was broken or what fixing it would look like. A Structural Question would have named that gap before proposing a fix: “We keep circling around whether trust exists. Let’s separate that from what we’re actually going to do next.”

And when the exchanged turned into a list of grievances about the board member's own behavior, that was the moment for a Reframe Question instead of a counter-accusation: "Help me turn that into something specific. What is it you need me to address?"

The executive was half right. They saw the real problem. But diagnosing trust correctly and then delivering a blunt verdict, a tit-for-tat, and an unearned fix is still four missed opportunities in a single conversation. The offer to meet weekly wasn't declined because trust-building was a bad idea. It was declined because nothing in the conversation had actually built any.

Leadership Rule: The most powerful move in a disagreement is rarely the best answer. It's the next question.

What to Say Instead: "Before I answer that, help me understand what you're actually asking."

CHAPTER 6: SAYING “NO” WITHOUT SAYING “WAR”

7.

CHAPTER 7: DISAGREEMENT IN PUBLIC MEETINGS

8.

CHAPTER 8: WHEN MISINFORMATION ENTERS THE ROOM

9.

CHAPTER 9: DISAGREEING WITH PEOPLE WHO WANT ATTENTION

10.

CHAPTER 10: EGO, FEAR, AND THE NEED TO BE RIGHT

11.

CHAPTER 11: CHOOSING INSTITUTIONAL HEALTH OVER PERSONAL VINDICATION

12.

CHAPTER 12: BECOMING A STEWARD OF DISAGREEMENT

APPENDICES

A: THE NEXPHRASE PHRASEBOOK

B: DISAGREEMENT PREP SHEET

**C: LEADERSHIP AGREEMENT ON
DISAGREEMENT**



ABOUT THE AUTHOR

Matthew Johnson is a city manager, leadership advisor, and communication strategist who has spent more than twenty years inside the real rooms where difficult decisions are made. He has led municipal organizations through growth, controversy, and political transition, overseeing complex operations, major capital projects, and emotionally charged public issues.

He is the founder of NexPhrase™, a consultancy dedicated to helping leaders say what needs to be said when the stakes are high. His work focuses on high-trust communication, institutional leadership, and the language choices that shape outcomes in conflict.

Matthew writes and speaks about leadership, public service, and the human cost of broken disagreement. He lives in North Carolina with his wife, Jennifer, where they also operate a small family farm. When he is not working with leaders or writing, he can usually be found thinking about how words quietly change everything.